

1-4 Managing Expectations from Three Stakeholder Types – Expanded Information

The information below expands on what was discussed in the 1-4 video regarding what you should expect from Process-minded, Tactical, and Strategic stakeholders.

Process-oriented stakeholders

- They want project members to understand their current processes, issues with those processes, and the opportunities they believe exist for improvement
- They have detailed thoughts about what works well and what they DON'T want changed
 - If changes are proposed in those areas, it's prudent to spend extra time with them demonstrating how the areas they believe work well won't be compromised
- Flowcharts representing their business processes and what will change are typically helpful for describing project deliverables
- In some cases, these stakeholders will understand what "shortcuts" are being taken outside their team
 - In most cases, however, they won't, so ensure you talk with process-oriented stakeholders in different buildings, cities, or other geographic areas to understand any differences between documented processes, and what is actually performed in practice
- These stakeholders usually appreciate being shadowed so project team members can see exactly how they perform their work
 - Stakeholders who hesitate to accommodate a shadowing request should trigger detailed queries, and, if available, an examination of audit trails regarding how they produce their work
 - Their hesitation may indicate they are compromising their business processes in a way they don't want others to know about

Tactical-minded stakeholders

- Focus conversations on the efficiencies and inefficiencies of how business teams operate
- In a compassionate way, seek understanding of the goals the business has placed on them, where they feel they are succeeding, and where they may be struggling

- This will provide vital insight into their expectations
- Produce a way to fulfill those expectations, and they will become passionate supporters of the project
- Follow up often, especially when changes are proposed, as those changes can substantially impact team dynamics when process handoffs occur between groups
- These stakeholders are often the best people to help support (or become members of) a steering committee for the project
 - This is because they typically have a broad understanding of the business, from process level to strategy

Strategic stakeholders

- Strategic stakeholders are typically time-poor
 - Allowing for flexibility in scheduling meeting times and being prepared for schedule changes is wise
- Be prepared to hear different vocabulary from what you hear from process and tactical stakeholders
 - They typically discuss topics of a more general nature, and value an understanding of the business as a whole
 - For example, when working on a project to improve the efficiency of scheduling and performing commercial aircraft maintenance, process, and tactical stakeholders discussed parts inventory levels, staffing levels for licensed aircraft engineers and designers, and hangar availability
 - In contrast, the strategic stakeholders talked about overall aircraft availability, aircraft leasing across the business, and trends in passenger volumes
 - Discussion focused on how those elements could affect aircraft maintenance schedules and how we could make adjustments proactively
- For strategic stakeholders in government or industries that must comply with government regulations, the regulations and how they will affect efficiencies will be at the forefront of their minds
 - The more understanding you can convey about regulations, or regulatory changes being considered by legislative bodies, the more productive your conversations will be